How do we learn a language?

Hello and welcome to this first episode of the Cottongue podcast.

[00:00:10] Thank you for being with me today. I'm very happy that you're listening to this podcast.

[00:00:16] And to begin with, I'm going to explain the idea behind this podcast. So, what is the Cottongue podcast? It's simply for people who are learning French and cannot find interesting things to listen to.

[00:00:34] There are several types of people who learn French, for example beginners. For beginners, there are lots of exercises on the internet, books, and so on. And people who already have an advanced level can simply read, watch and listen to all the French media because they are able to understand them.

[00:01:02] But between the two, there are people at an intermediate level who cannot yet understand traditional French media, French-language media, because they are a little too complicated. People speak too quickly, for example. They use vocabulary with words that are a little complicated.

[00:01:25] So what I want to do with the Cottongue podcast is help you learn French, not through grammar, but by listening to interesting things on different subjects. For example, I'm going to talk to you about politics, society, culture, France, but also all the other countries, all the things that interest me and that might interest you too. In any case, that's what I hope.

[00:02:01] So I'm going to say a few words about myself and introduce myself, since this is the first podcast. My name is Hugo. I've been a teacher in Poland, in Warsaw, which is the capital of Poland, for several years. As I've told you, I'm making this podcast especially for people who are learning French and who have, I would say, an intermediate level. If these people, if you listen to this podcast, you'll be able to understand more and more things.

[00:02:42] The first time you listen, it's normal not to understand everything. You need to listen twice, three times, four times. And the more you listen, the more you'll understand. That's logical. And if there are words or passages that you cannot understand, you can use the transcript of this podcast. The transcript is on my website, cottongue.com, and you'll be able to find all the transcripts of all the episodes there.

[00:03:19] Today, we're going to talk about languages. How do you learn a language?

[00:03:25] To begin with, we need to distinguish between a native language and a foreign language. We only have one native language. We have just one native language. It's the language we learn when we're children. We need this language simply to talk to our parents, to our friends, to communicate, to pass on messages. Foreign languages are the other

languages. In general, we learn foreign languages at school. For example, in France, at school, we learn English, German, Spanish and Italian.

[00:04:10] How do we learn these foreign languages? Generally, there is a teacher, and this teacher tries to pass on, to explain, how the language works. Sometimes it works, and sometimes, unfortunately, it doesn't work very well.

[00:04:30] So, of course, there are now lots of different methods for learning a foreign language. You can learn at school, but you can also have a private teacher. You can try to learn on your own, independently. You can use apps, books, podcasts, videos, and so on, and so on. There are now lots of methods for learning a language.

[00:05:04] But today, we're not really going to talk about the different methods. We're going to talk more about theory. And when we talk about the theory of language learning, there is one person who is very important and very interesting: Professor Stephen Krashen. This professor works at the University of Southern California, at USC, and he specialises in theories of language learning. Learning a language means learning a foreign language.

[00:05:43] Why is Professor Stephen Krashen very important? Because in the 1980s he published several books and several articles that greatly influenced the way languages are taught in schools, middle schools, high schools and universities. So we're going to talk about this professor's theory, and thanks to this theory, you'll be able to make faster progress in French and learn French in a more natural way.

[00:06:21] You should also know that I created this podcast using Professor Stephen Krashen's theories. So this will help you better understand why I made this podcast and how this podcast can help you learn French.

[00:06:43] Are you ready? Then let's begin!

[00:06:51] To understand Stephen Krashen's theory, there are five hypotheses.

[00:06:57] The first hypothesis is a central hypothesis, a very, very, very important one. In the first hypothesis, Stephen Krashen says that we need to distinguish, to make a distinction, between acquisition and learning.

[00:07:16] So what does acquisition mean? Acquisition is a noun that comes from the verb acquire. To acquire something means to obtain something. For example, if you buy a car, you acquire that car: it belongs to you. What does it mean to "acquire a language"? Acquiring a language is when, as a child, you naturally, unconsciously start using a language. Why do you start using this language? Well, because you want to talk to your parents. You're hungry, you're cold, you want to sleep, so you need to try to express yourself, to get a message across to your parents. For Professor Stephen Krashen, that is the natural way to learn a language. And for him, it is the only effective way to be able to use a language.

[00:08:27] Learning, on the other hand, is something conscious. It is a conscious process. When you're at school, taking a French class, for example, you know that you're learning French. It's something conscious. For example, you learn grammar rules to understand how French works, what rules you need to follow in order to speak French.

[00:09:02] But Stephen Krashen thinks that when we learn a language in this way at school, when we learn grammar rules, we cannot use the language to communicate. And I saw that very, very often when I was at school. For example, in English, we have to learn all the irregular verbs, and we think that once we know all the irregular verbs, we'll magically be able to speak English. Obviously, that doesn't work very well. So, to summarise this first hypothesis, Stephen Krashen says that we need to learn a language in a more natural way, a little like the way children learn their native language.

[00:09:56] Of course, there has been a lot of criticism of this first hypothesis. I don't completely agree with this hypothesis either. I think we need to know grammar rules, but that isn't the priority. First, we need to try to communicate, to communicate even if we make mistakes, errors. That isn't very serious. What matters is passing on a message, expressing ourselves. And then, when you're able to do that, you can learn the rules so you can correct yourself and express yourself more clearly. But the priority is trying to express yourself, trying to speak.

[00:10:50] The second hypothesis is the monitor hypothesis. What is a monitor? It's a person who checks. For example, when you take the underground, there are ticket inspectors who ask whether you have your ticket for travelling. The inspector checks that you follow the rules.

[00:11:14] When we learn a foreign language, when we speak a foreign language, there is a monitor in our heads. This monitor tries to see whether we follow all the rules properly. That means grammar rules and pronunciation rules. And what's interesting about this monitor is that not everyone has the same monitor in their head. For example, if you're a fairly extroverted person, meaning a person who isn't afraid to speak and likes expressing themselves, then the monitor's role is fairly weak. The monitor doesn't have much influence over you. You talk, you talk, and it doesn't matter if you don't follow the rules. The monitor is almost absent.

[00:12:12] On the other hand, if you're introverted, then the monitor is very, very present. As soon as you try to speak, you first think about the rules, think of a perfect way to say something without making a mistake. Unfortunately, that isn't very good. It isn't a good method for being able to speak a foreign language. To speak a foreign language, you need to make mistakes, you need to try to pass on a message. If you don't try to express yourself, if you don't make mistakes, you cannot progress.

[00:12:54] So making mistakes isn't very serious. You shouldn't be afraid of making mistakes. It's normal. Even the most talented people, those who have the greatest talent for speaking foreign languages, even those people make mistakes. So that doesn't matter.

[00:13:14] To summarise this second hypothesis: we need to limit the monitor's influence.

[00:13:25] Now the third hypothesis. Professor Stephen Krashen's third hypothesis is the natural order of acquisition. Professor Krashen says that every language has a natural order of acquisition. What does that mean? It means that every person acquires a language by following the same order. This order doesn't depend on the person. It depends only on the language.

[00:13:59] Each language has its own order. For example, in French, articles are something fairly difficult to learn, to master. We start using them right from the beginning, but in general students make many, many mistakes. It takes a very, very long time to be able to use articles properly. That is the natural order of a language.

[00:14:30] I don't completely agree with this theory, because I think that depending on your native language, the language you learned as a child, you'll learn a foreign language differently. For example, when a Chinese student learns French, they don't learn it in exactly the same way as an American student. For American students, there are similarities between English and French, so it's a little easier to learn certain rules, for example how to use articles, because English has articles too.

[00:15:24] Now the fourth hypothesis. The fourth hypothesis is the input hypothesis. In French, we don't have a good word to translate that, so I'm going to use the English word input. This is also a very, very important hypothesis in Krashen's theory. This hypothesis says that an individual learns a language, a person learns a language, when they try to understand messages, when they try to understand content. For example, when you read an article, when you watch a video in French and try to understand the message.

[00:16:10] But be careful: if this article is too easy, you won't learn anything new, you won't progress, you won't make any progress. To acquire a language, you need to try to understand things that are a little too difficult for you, things that are at a slightly higher level than yours, things that are a little complicated to understand at first. Because at that point, your brain will make an effort. It will use the context, for example, to try to understand them.

[00:16:53] How can your brain understand a word it doesn't know? It can use pictures. It can understand an explanation of that word. That's why I think it's more interesting to understand a word through its definition rather than through its translation. Well, sometimes that's impossible, of course. But ideally, if there is a word you don't know, look for its definition in French. Because that will require an effort, and that effort will allow your brain to work and to memorise, to remember that word better.

[00:17:45] So that is Professor Krashen's fourth hypothesis. You need to try to understand things that are a little too difficult for you. He also says that understanding is more important than expressing yourself. For Professor Krashen, we make progress only, exclusively, through comprehension. He thinks that using the language to speak or communicate doesn't

allow us to make progress. Of course, I don't agree with that. I think that using a language to communicate, to write something, to discuss something with someone also allows us to make progress, and it's even very, very important. I'll talk a little more about that later.

[00:18:47] And finally, the last hypothesis, the fifth hypothesis, is the affective filter hypothesis. What is a filter? I'll take an example to explain it to you. In a coffee machine. In a coffee machine, you need to use a filter to separate the liquid from the coffee grounds. So a filter is something that retains, keeps certain things, and lets other things pass through. "Affective" is something connected with feelings, emotions. It comes from "affection". So an "affective filter" means that when you experience positive or negative emotions, this influences your acquisition of the language. For example, if you're very motivated, if you have confidence in yourself, you're in a better frame of mind to understand a language. It's easier. You think you're capable of doing it, so it becomes easier to understand that language.

[00:20:09] On the other hand, if you don't have confidence in yourself, if you think you're not capable of learning a language, it will be more difficult, because the filter in your brain will prevent these things, this message, from passing through and reaching your brain. That's why, when we learn a language, the atmosphere, the environment, is very, very important. If you're in a calm atmosphere, if you feel good, if you feel confident, learning a language will be easier. On the other hand, if you're stressed or sad, if you're afraid to express yourself, your filter, your affective filter, will block the message, and you won't be able to understand the message. That's why, if you learn a language with a teacher, it's very important to have a good relationship with that person, to feel confident. If you're afraid of making mistakes because of that person, you're not in a good frame of mind for learning the language.

[00:21:34] The conclusion of all these hypotheses and of Krashen's theory is that it isn't very important to have a great deal of grammar knowledge in order to be able to use a language. That is somewhat counterintuitive, in France, for example, because in France we're very, very, very rational. And in France, we think we need to know the rules well before we can apply something. For example, with a language, we think that if we don't learn grammar first, we'll never be able to speak a language. And that isn't a good method. I don't know anyone for whom that method has worked.

[00:22:24] So to acquire a language, you need to use it to understand messages. Every day, you need to try to understand something in French: an article, a video, an email, an advertisement, anything, as long as you're trying to understand a message. The best methods for learning a foreign language are methods that offer lots of content, for example articles, videos, texts and so on, lots of interesting content, in a stress-free atmosphere. Don't trust a method that focuses on grammar. That doesn't work. Grammar can help you understand something when there's a message you don't understand, or a structure you don't understand. But grammar shouldn't be the foundation of your learning. Instead, try to understand things, to understand videos, to understand articles.

[00:23:37] You've understood that the most important thing is to find things that interest you, things you'll want to read, watch, listen to, and so on. If we want to understand something or understand someone, we'll make more of an effort. We won't think, "Right, now I have to do some French," but rather, "Today, I'm going to read a really interesting article, and that article is in French."

[00:24:15] With this podcast, I'm also going to talk to you about different subjects. Today I've talked to you about languages, but next time we'll talk about a completely different subject. And I won't talk to you about grammar. I'll just explain things to you, tell you stories that might interest you. I hope they'll interest you.

[00:24:41] So, as I've told you, unlike Professor Krashen, I think we also need to use the language to express ourselves, because when you use a language to express yourself, when you try to communicate, it allows you to do three things.

[00:24:59] First, it allows you to identify problems. When you see that there's something you cannot say, that you cannot express, then you'll look for a way to do it. And by looking for that way to do it, you'll learn a new structure.

[00:25:19] It also allows you to check what you've learned, to test what you've learned. For example, if you've learned a new structure or a new expression, and you use it to talk to someone, if that person doesn't understand the structure, it means that it doesn't work, that you haven't learned the right structure or that you need to use it differently.

[00:25:48] And the last important thing when you use a language to communicate is that it allows you to build confidence in yourself. And that's very, very important for speaking a foreign language. When you gain confidence, when you see that you're able to express yourself, to use that language, it's very, very rewarding, and it encourages you to continue. It allows you to stay motivated, and that's extremely important. But for that, of course, you need a guide, a person who corrects you, listens to you and helps you progress. That's my job, because I'm a French teacher and coach. So if you need someone to listen to you, to work with you, to suggest interesting things to read, watch and listen to, you can visit my website and send me an email. And I'll be very happy to help you.

[00:27:03] That's it. This is the end of this podcast, so thank you all for listening to me. Thank you very much. I'm really very happy if you've listened to this podcast right to the end. To find the podcast transcript, you can go to my website, cottongue.com, and you'll find the transcript there.

[00:27:28] Next week, in the next podcast, we'll talk about robots: how can we live with robots, and can they replace us? I hope you'll join me again next week for this new podcast. In the meantime, I invite you to try to understand as many things as possible, to read articles, to do a little French every day. Every day, try to understand something in French. Thank you, everyone. Have a good week, and see you soon!